The Crisis and US-India Relations Deteriorate

Over September and October, opportunities for a peaceful resolution of the crisis dissipated as the stakeholders became increasingly inflexible. The Nixon administration continued to resist calls for pressure on Pakistan. Instead, it asserted that India needed to de-escalate first. By late August, with refugees continuing to stream in and Islamabad's stand becoming even more rigid, however, Gandhi had decided that a political settlement was unlikely and India needed to tighten the screws on Pakistan. She traveled to Moscow at the end of September to seek more pressure on Islamabad and military supplies in case India had to go to war. The Soviets, who had continued to urge restraint, gave up on Islamabad and were fully on board with Delhi by mid- to late October. Also seeking broader diplomatic support, Gandhi embarked on what many later saw as a preemptive justification tour, with a stop in Washington as well.[198]

Nixon and Kissinger continued to view the crisis through global glasses, worrying about China's reaction to their stance. Kissinger insisted, "We are willing to do anything if the Indians will give us 6 months to turn around in."[199] That period was crucial because of the president's upcoming trips to Beijing and Moscow ahead of the 1972 elections. Thus Kissinger rejected suggestions by NSC and State Department contingency planners. They had recommended warning Beijing that provocative Chinese border incidents in the event of India-Pakistan hostilities would affect Sino-US relations. The subsequent November contingency planning document would also not correctly gauge the president's mood. It would continue to mention the commitment to consult with Delhi in the event of a Chinese attack against India.[200]

But China now had to factor in the Soviet reaction before taking any such step. While Beijing publicly pledged support for Pakistan, a surprised Kissinger noticed "less passion and more caution" from Zhou in October. In November, he tried unsuccessfully to draw out Huang Hua, the Chinese permanent representative at the UN, further on the subject.[201] State Department and allied officials expected this Chinese reticence to persist.[202]

India kept a close eye on Sino-Pakistani interactions. Gandhi told the British foreign secretary that, compared to the 1965 India-Pakistan war, Chinese support to Pakistan was thus far falling short.[203] The Indian chargé